Which join do I reach for?

ASK 1 Compare rows within one table?

no

ASK 2 Need every possible pair?

no

ASK 3 Need columns from both tables?

yes

ASK 4 Which unmatched rows must survive?

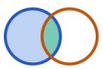
yes → **SELF JOIN** — one table, two aliases

yes → **CROSS JOIN** — every pair, no ON (5 × 4 = 20)

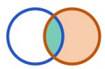
no → **EXISTS / NOT EXISTS** — match check, no duplicates

none → 

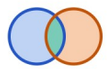
INNER JOIN
keeps matches only

left table's → 

LEFT JOIN
keeps the left table's orphans (Sneha)

right table's → 

RIGHT JOIN
keeps the right table's orphans (Debate)

both → 

FULL JOIN
keeps both sets of orphans

FOUR GOTCHAS

NULL never matches.
Sneha's club_id is NULL, so ON s.club_id = c.club_id can never pair her. That is why she is an orphan.

Bare JOIN = INNER JOIN.
OUTER is optional after LEFT, RIGHT or FULL. The side word never is. FULL INNER JOIN does not exist.

MySQL has no FULL JOIN.
Write LEFT JOIN ... UNION ... RIGHT JOIN. Use UNION, not UNION ALL, or every matched row appears twice.

Skip NATURAL JOIN in real code.
A new same-named column silently changes the join. Use ON, or USING (col). For RIGHT JOIN, swap the tables and use LEFT.